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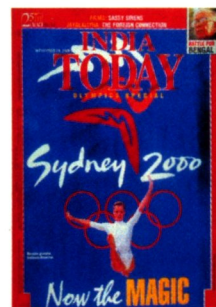
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For China, the Olympics were billed as its great coming out party, a unique chance to showcase the impressive strides it had made in recent years. It was a party the rest of the world will not forget in a hurry. From the spell-binding Opening Ceremony to the flawless organisation, the stunning stadiums and the record-breaking performances they showcased, this was undoubtedly the greatest Games ever. In one fortnight, China's image in the world was transformed beyond imagination, the doomsday predictions vanishing as fast as Osian Bolt ran the 100 metre.

No other Olympics in history has been as expensive, so meticulously planned and on such a grand scale. The total cost of the Olympic Games in Beijing was an estimated \$65 billion, five times the cost of the 2004 Olympics in Athens. For China, it has been money well spent. Beijing hosted a Games that was high quality in terms of sporting performance and organisation—everything ran like clockwork and the involvement of ordinary Chinese people was a large part of that success: a total of around 1.7 million volunteers were involved in these Games at all levels. The pollution control measures worked, athletes were looked after and secure and ordinary Chinese worked round the clock, surmounting barriers of language and communication to host the world's biggest sporting extravaganza.

In the process, they dazzled the watching world and the cherry on top of the Beijing cake was the performance of their athletes. China's gold medal tally of 51 is the highest by any nation since the break-up of the Soviet Union. China won 100 medals in 25 different sports. It was the first time since 1936 that a country other than the US or the Soviet Union/Russia led the gold medal list. That is largely due to the seven years of planning and preparation, the selection process, motivation, coaching and instilling nationalist pride. Says Deputy Editor Sharda Ugra who has covered two Olympics: "Despite a successful Games, the Chinese delegation head said they still 'lagged behind' on several counts. Obviously, they have new targets now. London better watch out."

For India to match that organisational and sporting success will be a Herculean task. Undoubtedly, China is a dictatorship and can get everyone voluntarily or involuntarily, to achieve their goal. India is as messy as it gets. Our best indoor sport is politics which is rampant in our sports bodies. The silver lining is that this was India's best performance at the Olympics which may inspire our political leadership and those in charge of sports, to flush out the politics, nepotism and bureaucracy which have strangled Indian sports and give it a higher priority. Our cover story looks at what China did to achieve sporting superpower and what India needs to do to emulate that example. The dragon has dazzled, now the elephant needs to stop lumbering along and break into a Bolt-type 100m dash.



Our Sept 2000 cover

Aroon Purie
(Aroon Purie)